own annihilation in the Khord Kabul Pass. Just as the Soviet puppet Najibullah survived much longer than anyone expected after the departure of the Soviet army in the 1980s, so Shah Shuja might have survived indefinitely as King of Afghanistan had he not been treacherously assassinated by his own godson for reasons of personal pique and jealousy.

The resistance of the Afghan sources has a slightly different dramatis personae to those given in the British accounts: Mir Masjidi and his Kohistanis and Aminullah Khan and his Logaris are both much more prominent than in the British sources, or indeed in those later Afghan accounts written later under Barakzai patronage which emphasise the central role of the victorious dynasty in the uprising – something that was actually only true for the final stages of the revolution.

More importantly, thanks to the Afghan sources the leaders of the Afghan resistance suddenly come into view as rounded figures, human beings with full emotional lives and with individual views and motivations. While the British sources see only an undifferentiated wall of treacherous bearded 'bigots' and 'fanatics', thanks to the new sources it is now possible to understand why it was that individual Afghan leaders, many of them loyal supporters of Shah Shuja, chose to risk their lives and take up arms against the apparently invincible forces of the Company. The venerable Aminullah Khan Logari was insulted by a junior British officer and lost his lands for refusing to pay increased taxes to the Crown. The hot-headed young Abdullah Khan Achakzai had his mistress seduced by Alexander Burnes and was mocked when he tried to retrieve her. Mir Masjidi was about to turn himself in when contrary to all understandings the British attacked his fort and massacred his family; the fort was then seized and turned into the centre of the British provincial government and his lands shared among his enemies. Most fully sketched of all is the sophisticated and complex figure of Akbar Khan, who loved Hellenistic Gandharan sculpture, wanted to import western education and was regarded in Kabul as the most dashing of the resistance leaders. The *Akbarnama* even includes a detailed description of the pleasures of his wedding bed. The caricature 'treacherous Muslim' of the British sources transforms before our eyes into an Afghan matinee idol.

The Afghan sources also present us with a mirror which allows us, in the words of Alexander Burnes's cousin Robbie Burns, 'To see ourselves as others see us'.[13] For according to the Afghan epic poets, Burnes, far from being the romantic adventurer of western accounts, was instead the